the era of a mounting risk of nuclear war from the era of a demilitarization of human life.

Under the INF agreement, more than fifteen hundred deployed Soviet nuclear warheads would be removed and all Soviet ground-launched intermediate-range missiles in Europe, including the SS-20s, would be destroyed; on the U.S. side, all Pershing II and ground-launched cruise missiles, with some four hundred deployed warheads, would be destroyed, plus backup missiles on both sides. As part of the agreement, each nation was permitted to make on-site inspections in the other country to verify compliance with the agreement.

It was the first time in history that any nations had ever agreed not only to stand down but to *destroy* nuclear missiles.

The next day, Gorbachev came back to the White House and we agreed that our next goal was to achieve a fifty-percent reduction of strategic missiles on both sides. On this "morning after," I think we both felt as if we'd participated in something important, and we relaxed a little. I told him I'd been collecting stories about the Russians; although there were quite a few I'd heard that I *couldn't* tell him, I told him one about an American and a Russian who were arguing about the respective merits of their countries. The American said, "Look, in my country I can walk into the Oval Office and I can pound on the president's desk and say, 'Mr. President, I don't like the way you are running the country,'" to which the Russian said, "I can do that, too." The American said, "You can?" and his friend said:

"Sure, I can go into the Kremlin and pound on the General Secretary's desk and say, 'Mr. General Secretary, I don't like the way President Reagan is running his country.'"

The interpreter translated the joke, and when he got to the punch line, Gorbachev howled.